9 Cards Lake Fishing - Official Game Rulebook

1. Game Overview & Components

Thematic Overview

In *9 Cards Lake Fishing* , players step into the boots of elite professional fishermen competing on a shared, dynamic lake to hook and land the most impressive catch. Players must carefully manage their colored bait supplies, calculate casting distances, and expend physical power to roll dice from a shared pool. Anglers compete for priority at choice fishing spots, reeling in regular fish from shallow and deep waters before confronting the legendary Kingfish. The angler who accumulates the highest total Victory Points by the end of the competition is crowned Master Angler.

Component List

- **1 Tracking Card:** Serves as the central tracking board for player Power Levels (scale 1–5) and Kingfish Health Points (HP). Set aside during setup.
- **7 Regular Fish Cards:** Represent the standard fish population residing in the lake's shallow and deep waters.
- **1 Kingfish Card:** The apex trophy fish that resides at the bottom of the lake deck and triggers game end upon capture.
- **7 Dice:** A shared physical pool used across all movement, spot priority, and fishing encounter rolls.
- **2 Score Tokens:** Used to track each player's accumulated Victory Points.
- **2 Strength Tokens:** Placed on the Tracking Card to track each player's current Power Level.
- **1 Kingfish Token:** Placed on the Tracking Card to track remaining Kingfish HP.
- **6 Bait Tokens:** 3 tokens per player (2 Red, 2 Blue, 2 Green total).

Fish Card Anatomy

Every Fish Card features four distinct attributes critical to gameplay:

- **Bait Type (Front):** Displays the specific bait color (Red, Blue, or Green) required for an optimal catch.
- **Catch Points / Victory Points (Front):** The exact VP awarded to the player upon successfully landing the card.
- **Power Value (Front):** The numeric threshold that player dice rolls must strictly exceed to land the fish.
- **Size (Back):** Displayed on the reverse side of the card and visible while in the stacked deck pile. Allows players to gauge potential card value or strategically trick opponents regarding target selection.

2. Game Setup & Deck Preparation

Follow these steps in order to set up the central tracking board, player supplies, and the 8-card Lake Deck:

- **Board & Tracker Setup**
- Place the **Tracking Card** in the center of the play area within equal reach of all players. (Note: The Tracking Card is set aside as the board, leaving 8 cards to form the Lake Deck).
- Place each player's **Strength Token** on space **3** of the 5-point Power Level scale on the Tracking Card.
- Place the **Kingfish Token** on the Tracking Card's HP track at its maximum starting value (**15 HP** for standard play, or **20 HP** when using the 2-Player Balanced Variant).
- **Player Supply Distribution**
- Distribute **3 Bait Tokens** (1 Red, 1 Blue, 1 Green) and **1 Score Token** to each player.
- **Simplified 2-Tier Deck Assembly (8-Card Lake Deck)**
- **Step 1 (Pool Creation):** Gather all 7 regular fish cards and shuffle them face-down into a single temporary pool.

- **Step 2 (Shallow Water Layer - Top):** Deal 4 regular fish cards face-down to form the Shallow Water top layer.
- **Step 3 (Deep Water Layer - Bottom):** Shuffle the remaining 3 regular fish cards together with the 1 Kingfish card face-down to form the Deep Water bottom layer (4 cards total).
- **Step 4 (Lake Deck Formation):** Place the 4-card Shallow Water layer directly on top of the 4-card Deep Water layer. This creates the complete face-down **8-card Lake Deck** (4 Shallow + 4 Deep = 8 Deck Cards).

3. Core Mechanics & Resource Systems

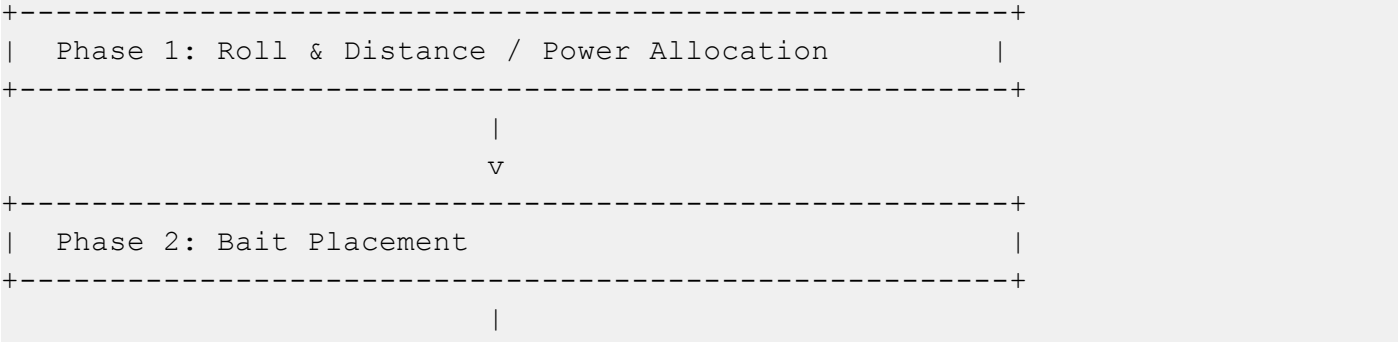
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[RULE BOX: Shared 7-Dice Pool]
* All turn actions, casting distance calculations, spot competition
roll-offs, and catch attempts utilize a single shared pool of 7 physical
dice.
* Dice drawn from the pool for active turn actions are returned to the pool
immediately after catch resolution or tracker updating.

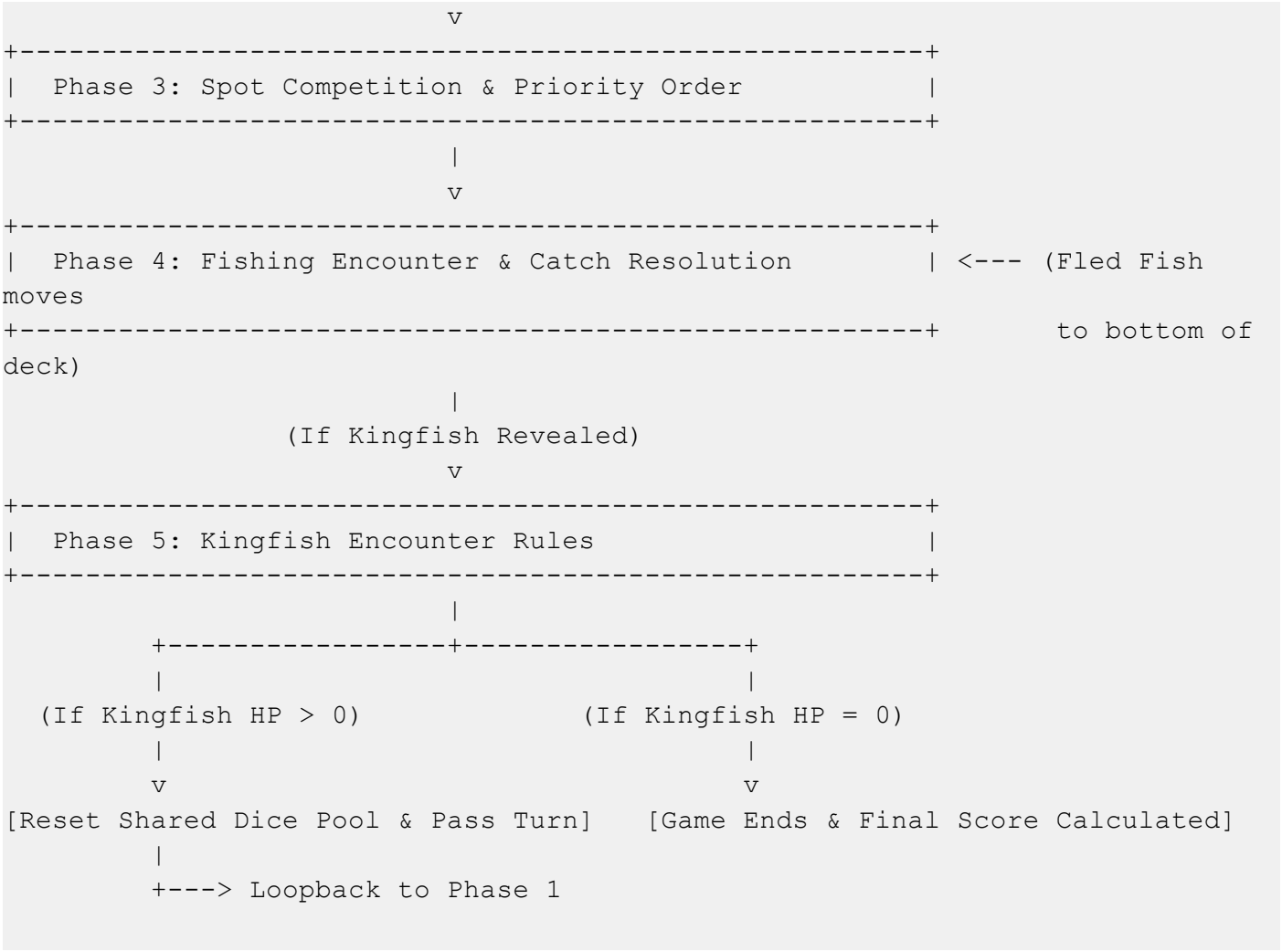
[RULE BOX: Power Level Tracker Expenditure]
* Each player's physical Strength Token tracks their current Power Level on
the 1–5 scale printed on the Tracking Card (starting at space 3).
* Power Boost Expenditure: A player may spend Power Level by moving their
Strength Token down on the track. Spending 1 Power Level allows the player to
draw +1 extra die from the shared pool for any spot competition or catch
roll.
* Banking Power: Unused or reserved power dice during turn allocation or
catch resolution may be banked to raise the player's Strength Token up to the
maximum Power Level of 5.

[RULE BOX: Bait System & Retrieval Rules]
* Players place colored Bait Tokens (Red, Blue, Green) on target card
positions along the Lake Deck.
* Free Retrieval (Successful Catch): When an angler successfully catches a
fish, their placed Bait Token is returned to their personal supply free of
charge (0 Power cost).
* Paid Retrieval (Failed Catch / Fled Fish / Manual Retrieval): If a catch
attempt fails, if a target fish flees to the bottom of the deck, or if a
player manually retrieves a deployed bait token, the player must spend 1
Power Level (lowering their Strength Token by 1 space) to return the Bait
Token to their active supply.
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4. Turn Sequence & Phase Breakdown

Gameplay proceeds sequentially through five distinct phases each turn. Once a turn completes, active dice return to the shared pool, and priority passes to the next angler.





Phase 1: Roll & Distance / Power Allocation

1. The active player rolls **1 initial die (1D)** from the shared pool.
2. The player selects a target card position from distance range **1 to 6** in the Lake Deck stack.
3. **Calculation:** Subtract the chosen target distance from the initial roll result (Initial Roll - Distance = Remaining Power Dice). The remaining value represents the number of dice drawn from the shared pool available for rolling during the turn.
4. **Banking Option:** Instead of rolling all available power dice, an angler may choose to roll a subset and bank the unused dice to increase their Strength Token on the Power Level track (+1 Power Level per banked die, up to max 5).**Phase 1 Allocation Examples:**

- **Example A (Standard Allocation & Banking):** A player rolls a **6** on 1D and targets a card at **Distance 1** . Remaining Power Dice = 6 - 1 = 5 Dice. The player receives 5 Power Dice. They choose to roll 3 Dice for the catch and bank 2 unused dice, raising their Strength Token by +2 on the Power Level scale.
- **Example B (Short Roll / Power Expenditure):** A player rolls a **1** on 1D. Targeting a card at **Distance 1** requires 1 die (1 - 1 = 0 Power Dice), leaving zero dice for the catch attempt. To gain rolling power, the player spends **1 Power Level** from their tracker (lowering their Strength Token from space 3 to space 2), which draws **+1 extra die** from the shared pool to serve as 1 Power Die for the upcoming catch attempt.

Phase 2: Bait Placement

- Players choose from their personal supply of Bait Tokens (Red, Blue, Green) and deploy them onto target card positions in the Lake Deck.
- **Placement Strategy:** A player may distribute their 3 Bait Tokens across 3 separate target spots, or stack up to 3 Bait Tokens on a single target spot to heavily commit to a high-value fish.

Phase 3: Spot Competition & Priority Order

When multiple anglers deploy bait onto the exact same target position, priority to reveal the card and attempt the catch is resolved using the following hierarchy:

- **Priority 1 (Bait Match):** An angler whose deployed bait color matches the target fish card's required bait automatically wins priority over any player with non-matching bait.
- **Priority 2 (Dice Roll-Off):** If competing players both match or both fail to match the required bait color, a roll-off occurs. Both players roll dice drawn from the shared pool; the higher total roll wins priority.
- *Power Option:* Any competing player may spend **1 Power Level** (moving their Strength Token down 1 space) to add **+1 extra die** to their roll-off total.

Phase 4: Fishing Encounter & Catch Resolution

The player with priority reveals the target fish card face up and resolves the catch attempt:

- **Target Requirement Calculation:**
- **Matching Bait:** Target threshold equals the printed **Fish Power Value** .
- **Non-Matching Bait Penalty:** If the deployed bait color does not match the card requirement, the target threshold increases by **+1 additional point** (Target = Fish Power Value + 1).
- **Execution & Comparison:** The active player rolls their available power dice. To successfully land the catch, the total rolled value must **strictly exceed** the target threshold (Dice Total > Target Threshold).
- **Catch Success (Dice Total > Target Threshold):** The angler collects the fish card into their personal scoring pile. Their deployed Bait Token returns to their personal supply for **free (0 Power cost)** . Unused power dice return to the shared pool or update the Power Level track if banked.
- **Catch Failure (Dice Total <= Target Threshold):** The fish slips the hook and flees face-down to the **very bottom of the Lake Deck** . The player must spend **1 Power Level** to recover their deployed Bait Token.**Catch Resolution Examples:**
- **Example A (Matching Bait - Success):** Fish Power 10, Matching Bait (Target = 10). Player rolls 2 Dice resulting in 5 + 6 = 11. 11 > 10 -> **Result: Success!** Card collected; bait returned free (0 Power cost).
- **Example B (Matching Bait - Failure):** Fish Power 10, Matching Bait (Target = 10). Player rolls 2 Dice resulting in 3 + 6 = 9. 9 <= 10 -> **Result: Failure!** Fish flees to the deck bottom; player spends 1 Power Level to retrieve bait.
- **Example C (Non-Matching Bait Penalty - Failure):** Fish Power 6, Non-Matching Bait (Target = 6 + 1 = 7). Player rolls 1 Die resulting in 6. 6 <= 7 -> **Result: Failure!** (Needs strictly more than 7). Fish flees to the deck bottom; player spends 1 Power Level to retrieve bait.
- **Example D (Non-Matching Bait Penalty - Success):** Fish Power 6, Non-Matching Bait (Target = 6 + 1 = 7). Player rolls 2 Dice resulting in 4 + 4 = 8. 8 > 7 -> **Result: Success!** Card collected; bait returned free (0 Power cost).

Phase 5: Kingfish Encounter Rules

When the Kingfish card is revealed at the bottom of the Lake Deck, special boss encounter mechanics trigger:

- The Kingfish possesses massive stamina and cannot be landed in a single roll.
- **HP Reduction Mechanics:** During a Kingfish catch attempt, the active player rolls power dice against the Kingfish's target threshold (Matching Bait Target = Kingfish Power; Non-Matching Bait Target = Kingfish Power + 1).
- **Damage Math:** If the roll is successful (Dice Total > Target Threshold), the difference represents damage dealt (Damage Dealt = Dice Total - Target Threshold). Move the Kingfish Token down on the Tracking Card HP scale by an amount equal to the damage dealt.
- **Final Capture:** If a player's roll successfully reduces the Kingfish HP tracker to **0** , that angler lands the Kingfish, claims the Kingfish Card, and **immediately terminates the game** .

- If Kingfish HP remains above 0, the Kingfish stays face up at the bottom of the deck, and the turn passes to the next player.

5. Two-Player Balance Adjustments

To maintain high competitive tension and balance the effort required to whittle down the Kingfish in a 2-player game, apply the following adjustments:| Rule Feature | Standard Multi-Player Rules (3+ Players) | 2-Player Balanced Variant || ------ | ------ | ------ || **Kingfish Starting Health** | 15 HP | **20 HP** || **Kingfish VP Bonus** | 0 VP (Standard card point value only) | **+5 VP Catch Bonus** awarded to the player who completes the final catch on the Kingfish |

6. Game End & Victory Point Scoring

End-Game Trigger

The game terminates **immediately** during Phase 5 the moment an angler reduces the Kingfish's HP token on the Tracking Card to 0 and lands the Kingfish card.

Victory Point Calculation

Each player sums their final score using collected Fish Cards and applicable bonuses:

1. **Regular Fish Cards:** Sum all Catch Points (VP) printed on the front of collected regular Fish Cards.
2. **Kingfish Card:** Add the base Catch Points printed on the Kingfish Card to the catcher's total.
3. **2-Player Variant Bonus:** If playing with the 2-Player Balanced Variant, add the **+5 VP Catch Bonus** to the score of the angler who landed the Kingfish.

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|                                FINAL SCORE FORMULA
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| Total Score = (Sum of Regular Fish VPs) + (Kingfish Card VP) + (2P Variant
Bonus)|
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Victory Determination

The angler with the highest overall Victory Point total is declared the winner. In the event of a tie, the player who landed the Kingfish breaks the tie and claims victory.